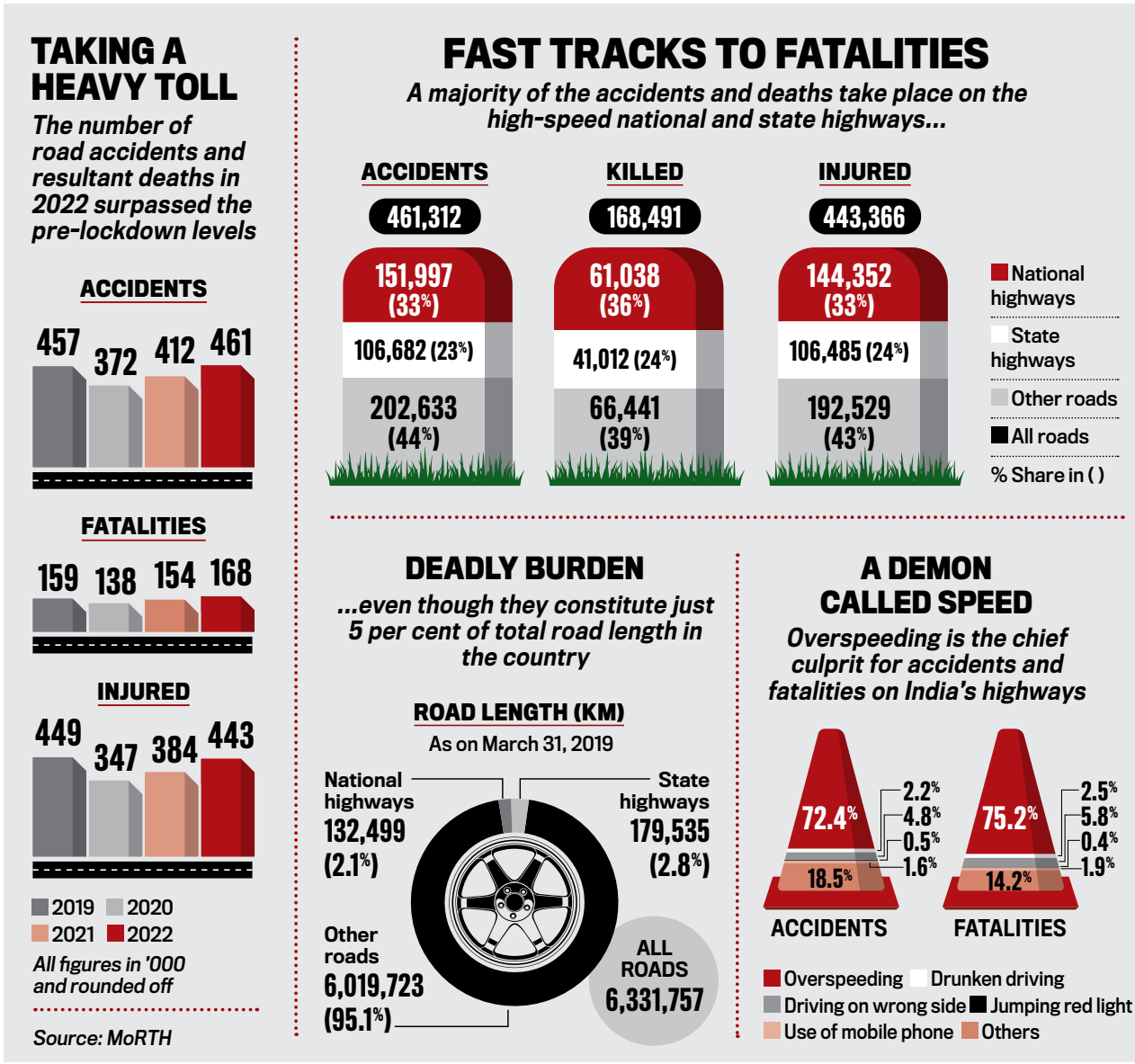


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

poor curve design and other obstacles

↘ Lack of enforcement both in the domain of providing licences and in failing to levy heavy penalties for violations

↘ Inadequate vehicle safety measures, be it lack of airbags or optimised vehicle body engineering to reduce crash impact

↘ Woeful lack of speedy access to treatment of accident victims and inadequate trauma care

THE ROAD ENGINEERING DANGER

Poor and thoughtless road engineering is not emphasised enough as a reason for road accidents in the country. When SaveLIFE started working with the central and state governments to investigate accidents and address engineering concerns, it was startled by the number of glaring engineering defects in many of the major highways. For instance, during a safety audit of the old Mumbai-Pune highway, it found 37 blocks that obscured driver vision, 21 roadside trees, 67 kerb stones, 162 sharp curves, 275 concrete structures on the road and 218 km of narrow stretches with no lane discipline. When Gadkari, who was a victim of a highway road accident himself in 2004 and suffered multiple bone fractures, assumed charge of MoRTH in 2014, he immediately made road safety audits of all the national and state highways mandatory. He tasked the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), the apex central government agency to develop, manage and maintain national highways, to identify accident blackspots and have these rectified on a time-bound basis.

The results were an eye-opener. By 2021, the NHAI had identified 5,352 blackspots based on accident and fatality data from 2016-2018. Of these, 4,005 blackspots have been permanently rectified and the remaining 1,300 are being attended to. The NHAI has spent an estimated Rs 15,700 crore so far to eliminate engineering defects identified in the blackspots. The interventions range from short-term basic measures